

THE PATH OF THE PHOENIX

CHAPTER 1. THE GRAY STORM – HOW TO KNOW YOU'RE IN IT



Signs: apathy, alcohol as a means of survival, devaluation. Let's talk about the consequences. Because apathy, alcohol, that ingrained feeling of being a "worthless creature" – these aren't the cause, but the consequence of a long run along the uneven road of life, a road full of potholes, jutting stones, muddy puddles, and all the other obstacles that life places in a person's path. While you're young, full of strength, you run confidently, looking only ahead, seeing the goal. You have a backpack on your shoulders, but there's not much in it yet, and it's not heavy. But the older you get, the more load you carry in that backpack (family, children, a responsible business, obligations of various kinds). Yet you keep running, never slowing the pace. Only over time, you start to notice that your feet catch on protruding obstacles more often, you stumble more – your foot lands in a hole, then in a puddle. You start looking down at your feet more and ahead, at your goal, less. The backpack gets heavier: it's long since accumulated heavy, useless things – a car on credit that eats up most of your salary, and, God forbid, a

mortgage on top of that; your wife's demand: "I'm tired, I want to go to Cyprus or somewhere"; you have to "help" mom at the dacha; we need new renovations – a QUEEN can't live in an apartment where the renovation was done only two years ago, and other such CRAP! And you keep running, you're thirsty, you feel exhaustion, your muscles ache, and only one thought takes root: I want to get rid of this load, sit down and rest for even a minute (go fishing alone or with friends, or hit the banya – in short, some relaxation and a reset). But then suddenly a bird flies by and drops its **shit** right on your head: "Aaah, you wanted to go to the banya?! And what about me?! My manicure, my get-together with the girls, who will stay with the kids, mom can't – her blood pressure!" And you lower your head, wipe the **shit** off your face while still running, and keep going. And then, at some moment, you trip and fall headlong onto the road, into the mud, slamming into the rocks, getting bruised and scraped. And there you are, lying there, then trying to get up, to lift your backpack – but it's impossibly heavy (the business collapsed or you got laid off, but the mortgage and loans remain). You want to lie there, gather your strength, and get back up to continue the marathon – maybe no longer running, but walking, with the help of a stick you found on the roadside (a gig as a courier). And from above, more **shit**: "Get up, you wretch! What are you, not a man? Can't earn a living – then be a househusband! Why do I come home from work to find the laundry not done, no food, and the floors not mopped?" And you sink back down again. You lie there, and all around, only bird **shit** keeps falling. You pull out a bottle of whiskey and take the first gulp. A slow warmth begins to flow through your body. With every next gulp, your thoughts grow foggier, you no longer look at the backpack, the **shit** stops bothering you – you have fallen into a soft, enveloping cloud of illusory peace, where there is no road, no wife's **shit**, no backpack. A familiar situation? And so, you finally fall asleep. You feel good and at peace, you are ALONE, and you never want to wake up – ever! Then a thought pierces through: what if I die? Then there will be no more of this load, all this filth, this cursed road! I will end up in a place where peace and silence reign, where you don't feel your body or gravity, where you can, like a neural network, generate images of your thoughts and desires! Even if there's nothing – a complete reset – it's still better than this current state! But what about the wife, the kids? The wife – God be with her, she'll manage, she said herself she wouldn't live with a **stinking alcoholic**, she'd find a worthy one, it's as easy as pie for her... The children – yes, that's a tough one, but also solvable. They have a mother, and when they grow up – they'll figure it out! But even that is so completely indifferent to me now.

You wake up at night and drink again – you need to fall asleep, to sink back into that soft cloud... In the morning you wake up and see chaos all around: empty bottles, food scraps on the floor, cigarette butts in a phlegm-stained cup. And all around, the GRAY STORM howls and swirls – huge, malevolent, its gusts grabbing you and smashing you against the floor. You've fallen, your legs gave out. You're sitting at the dacha on the second floor, and you need to go to the bathroom – for that, you have to go down to the first floor. Ahead is a staircase, steep, dangerous, and your body is pickled in alcohol, you can't coordinate your movements – you step forward and might fall and break your neck. And then the staircase turns into a gigantic mouth, full of teeth and

burning resin, and it screams: "Come, run, I'm waiting for youuuuu!" You sober up, remember this nightmare – and only one thought pounds in your head: WHAT TO DO?!

Speaking for myself: I am no guru, no coach, no Chinese sage. For me, there were only two ways out. The first – to jump down and vanish into the boiling resin, to become a vile, sticky, stinking ash for my loved ones, one they could never wash off. The second – to search for a way out, to find a path to salvation. It always exists, that's just how this world is made. Only the way out is hidden deep, though it's right in plain sight – it's just that the littered mind often ignores it.

What saved me. When I was in technical college, one of my classmates (out of sheer natural stupidity, of course) was fooling around with nunchucks during a break. I was sitting at



my desk half-turned, talking to someone, when suddenly this "kind soul" (that's from Bulgakov's *The Master and Margarita*, for those who haven't read it) looped those two sticks around my neck from behind and started choking me (as a joke, of course). I couldn't break free and lost consciousness. Then – a blackout, followed by a complete awareness of myself, but already without a body. I felt so good, so light and calm. Where I was – I don't know, in some space, but clearly not an earthly one. Suddenly I caught myself thinking that I was rising upward, as if being drawn in. Around me

flew clots of something incomprehensible, resembling pulsating dark-orange oranges, and there were more and more of them. I rose and saw a light that began to form into a large, long pipe. Flashes of events from my then-sixteen-year-old life flickered through my mind. I rise, and at some point I feel: the pipe begins to split, divides into two long glowing sticks, and something gentle – no, rather calm – tells me, and it doesn't speak in sound, but precisely in information: "It's too early for you, go back, your work is not finished." And then I feel something gently stroking my cheeks, then suddenly an unimaginable heaviness – as if they've put a lead spacesuit on you – and I'm flying somewhere downward... The heaviness passes, and I realize that I'm not being stroked, but slapped, slapped with full-force palms. I came to and started yelling: "Are you idiots?! Stop it, that hurts!" When I finally fully regained consciousness, I saw my classmates standing around with frightened faces and eyes wide with terror. I was lying on the floor, and next to me stood that "kind soul" – pale, terrified. That's how I experienced clinical death, and now

I'm not afraid to die. So, if you decide to leave, to jump into the resin, you might not succeed, because you haven't fulfilled your purpose. Maybe you will, if you try hard enough and damage the body, but I'm afraid you'll have to answer for "damaging **government property**" issued to you for temporary use.

Then, in the middle of that storm, I remembered that experience of mine and got genuinely scared (about having to answer for damaging the property). And I decided to choose the second option – to find a way out. I opened my laptop and started writing in a notepad. I wrote down all my feelings, what I was doing, etc. I wanted to identify the state I was in, to materialize it and block it. I wrote questions (prompts) for DeepSeek that helped me, with the neural network's help, to identify this state. And here's the result – "THE GRAY STORM." The neural network, like a mirror, helped me drag out into the light all my secrets and problems, even those hidden from myself. I didn't go to psychologists or psychotherapists not because I'm tough and can do EVERYTHING MYSELF, but simply because I had no money. I emphasize: I am only speaking for myself. Every person has their own way out. But I will share the self-diagnosis method I developed – though not for free, because what a person receives for free or without effort, they don't value. And I went through this path myself, and it is precious to me.

Exercise for Chapter 1: "Write Down Your Gray Storm"

Take a notebook or open a new document. Write down everything you are feeling right now. Do not edit, do not judge, do not try to make it "beautiful." Just unload it. This is the first step toward understanding what is inside. In a week, read it again – and you will see what has changed.

CHAPTER 2. TWO PERSONALITIES – WHY THE PEOPLE CLOSE TO YOU DEVALUE YOU



April 10, 1995

We've broken down how a man ends up in the Gray Storm. Now we need to understand – why.

I'll speak for myself, based on the path I've walked.

From the start, I had a set of core beliefs embedded in me (hold your laughter – better take a look at yourself):

- I'm a good person.

- I'm responsible (work, relationships, family).
- I'm basically the "Sun," and people around me fall under my protection.
- I can achieve anything on my own.
- Wife and children are the most important things in life.
- I'm obliged to give my family the best.
- I'm obliged to take care of my parents.
- My in-laws are also part of the family.
- My main life attitude is positivity.
- I'm an optimist.
- See an opportunity? Act!

That's the mindset I entered adulthood with.

I'll start with the period after the army. I came back, re-enrolled in the institute (it was an evening program). I worked during the day, studied in the evenings, sometimes met up with friends to, as they say now, "hang out." I had money – not a huge amount, but by the standards of the '90s, more than my classmates, so our get-togethers and hangouts were usually on my dime. Back then I had no idea about deposits or compound interest, or that you should set aside 10% of any amount to provide for yourself in old age – old age? Where was that? At the time, 30-year-olds seemed like real adults to me, and I was still a long way from that age.

Only my grandmother (she was an economist-engineer at a major research institute) told me: "My dear grandson, you should always have a stash for a rainy day, especially hidden from your wife." I didn't have such a wonderful thing as a wife yet, but I heard my grandmother's advice, and I ALWAYS had money – different amounts, but I was never completely broke like many of my classmates.

I never spent much on girls, especially not on one-night stands or casual flings. Sure, I'd take them to a café (I didn't go to restaurants back then – I thought I wasn't at that level yet), go for a walk, buy flowers, ice cream, sometimes a taxi. No expensive gifts, no bouquets of a million roses, or other nonsense. And back then, girls valued a person's character more than his wallet. (Stop – if you disagree, that's your personal opinion and has nothing to do with my story.)

At the time, there was a small Soviet-French, later Russian-French, joint venture. We did restoration and made artistic bronze pieces, and my father appointed me as executive director. We rented space in a former shipbuilding design bureau in the center of Leningrad (I still can't get used to its current name, even though so many years have passed). There were two small workshops and a tiny office.

Next door worked a middle-aged man – he used to be a model maker, but now made picture frames. We got along really well; he was a child of the Leningrad siege and told me a lot about those times – I found it fascinating. One day he asked: "Tell me, do you have a girlfriend?" I said: "No, not right now." "Well, I have a daughter – not biological, but I've raised her since she was little. She's good, beautiful, and I'd like to find a decent guy for her, because all sorts are hanging around... Would you like to meet her?" I said: "Why not?"

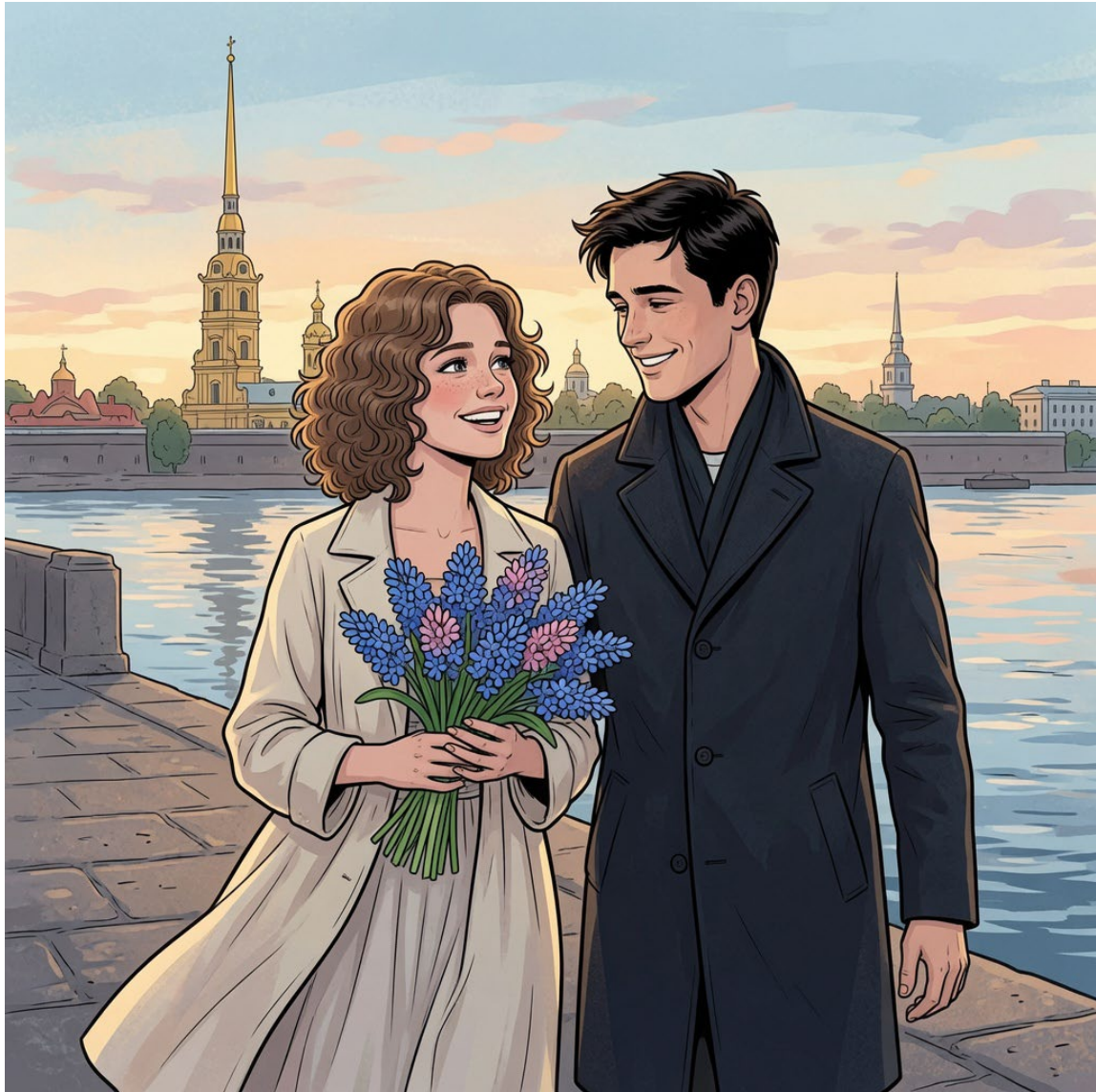
We agreed that I'd come to their place, ostensibly to chat with him, and then we'd see how it went. I arrived around 4 p.m., in a suit and an expensive coat (that was my style back then – I always wore a suit and tie), and brought some champagne. I rang the doorbell; the man opened – let's call him Alexei Nikolayevich, it'll be easier. I came in, and he said that Yulenska wasn't home yet, but she'd be coming soon.

And then she came. I didn't expect to meet such a beautiful and sweet girl – she was 18, I was 22. We talked, had dinner, and I left. I had work, studies, and it seemed that meeting was starting to fade from memory. I continued my free bachelor life, worked, and after classes in the evenings I'd meet up with friends.

About two weeks later, my cell phone rang – yes, a cell phone in '95 (I'd pulled off a little scam and bought a Motorola with a flip cover; it was cool, like a gangster's or a businessman's phone!). It was Alexei Nikolayevich: "Hello! Why haven't you called Yulenska?" – "Well, I don't know, she didn't call me, so I figured she wasn't interested." – "No, no, she was just raised that way – the man should make the first move. She really liked you, and she's been beside herself because you've been silent. Call her, take her for a walk, okay?" – "Alright, I'll call in a few days." – "No, call her today, she's waiting."

And I called! With that call, my carefree, free life ended.

I fell in love – hard. What hooked me? Like any mentally healthy man – her femininity, her meekness. She looked at me like I was a god, listened to my stories about the architecture of our city when we walked, about art and so on (I was already quite well-read and educated back then).



We started living together at my parents' place – or rather, she ran to me and said she'd left her family because her parents didn't want us to see each other (I was already hooked by then, and they knew it perfectly well). My parents were in shock, but what can you do with a "love-struck fool" – he doesn't listen to anyone!

Anyway, that's all lyricism. Let's get to the main point. At first, everything went smoothly: love, I showed Yulenska off to my friends (you can't help but brag about such a beauty!). But the warning bells started ringing. She began to show her character, small caprices, if things didn't go her way. And me? I'm a gentleman, so I thought: "Well, she's just a girl being capricious, she'll mature, it'll pass" (funny, isn't it?). Then we rented an apartment and started living alone. We often had friends over, hangouts, alcohol (by the way, she didn't drink, and back then I knew my limits – not like a year ago: two 0.7 bottles of cognac as the norm. Remembering it makes me shudder).

Things were heading toward a wedding.

One time after work, a buddy and I had a couple of beers near the metro and were about to head our separate ways, but the conversation was long and interesting, so I suggested: "Let's go to my place" – and we went. We get home – well, a slight smell, just two cans of beer, perfectly sober and not planning to continue. The door is opened by my future mother-in-law, and right from the threshold: "Are you drunk? She's waiting for you, and you're out drinking somewhere?" My buddy froze on the doorstep – he was half a head taller than me, but it seemed to me that after such a "sweet greeting" he shrank by half. Then Yulenska shot out like a jack-in-the-box: eyes blazing, pure rage, and the same kind of greeting! My buddy made a quick exit, and I was left alone with these lovely creatures.



I answered harshly (that was the first and last time) that it was none of her business, she wasn't my wife to behave like that in MY home. Yulenska bolted out the door and ran toward the elevator. Her mother said: "Why are you standing there? Run after her!" My reply changed the mask on her face: "I'm not a sprinter to run after women. If you need to – you run. And frankly, I'm tired of this pointless scandal. Here's money for a taxi – get out of here with your daughter!"

My future mother-in-law's face changed, her voice softened, her tone turned friendly: "What are you saying, come on, you two just had a spat, lovers' quarrels are soon mended." And so on. "She'll probably be back soon, but maybe you could go look for her, it's late outside..."

And here I made the MOST FATAL mistake of my life! I thawed and was about to go find my princess, but Her Highness came back on her own. She walked in, so meek, looking at me with her head slightly bowed, and my inner angel whispered: "You idiot, you almost let the love of your life slip away!" And I forgave her.

I looked at her – head down, wet eyes, quiet voice. And something inside me tightened. I suddenly felt guilty – as if I had started the scandal, as if I was the one who was bad. I wanted to save her. I wanted her to smile. I forgot my anger, my words, the fact that I was right. I felt warmth spread inside me – I loved her again, I was ready to forgive everything again. And I forgave her. Not because she apologized, but because I couldn't stand her pain.

Do you understand what I DID?

Months passed, during which the caprices and control only increased. But one positive thing remained – my mother-in-law had been on my side since then and stayed that way for life. She wasn't an impulsive woman, and she had reason – she understood that if I slipped away, they'd lose me.

I forgave. What did I achieve with my forgiveness? Did I show magnanimity? No. I showed that it's okay to treat me like that! If I had kicked them out back then – she would have come back anyway, but meek and obedient (her mother would have brainwashed her, after all, they'd chosen me for good reason – a good resource).

Then came the wedding. I thought that would solve everything. Wedding, family, official status – she'd finally calm down. Fool. She didn't want to calm down; she wanted power. And I gave it to her when I forgave her the first time. I just didn't understand back then that forgiveness isn't an act of mercy – it's an act of consent. Consent to being devalued, and you accepting it.

The first years of marriage were the best at that time. I loved her, she loved me too. She was affectionate, caring, a good cook. She knew how to be that same girl who looked at me like a god. But as soon as I relaxed – the other mode kicked in. And I didn't understand which one was the real her. I decided: "She's just growing up," "hormones," "teenage years" – she was four years younger than me. I made excuses for her every time she crossed the line. And every time I made excuses, I moved the line further, until it disappeared completely.

Then the girl grew up and gained strength. And now I, like a fool, looked at her and blew dust off her. I put my wife on a pedestal. The higher the pedestal, the smaller my significance. Sure, I occasionally pushed back, and that led to another scandal.

What happened? I think Yulenska perfectly understood: I was raised to be a good, obedient boy (though even in that upbringing there was always a rebellious streak inside me – that's what saved me later; I just let it do its work, defending my interests) and she identified the pressure point. That point was my attitude toward scandals. In the family I grew up in, there were no scandals; my parents never raised their voices at each other – unlike her family. If I did something that contradicted Yulenska's wishes and will, she'd switch to an authoritative tone and start shouting, reproaching me, screwing guilt into my head, plus constant control: "Where were you? Where are you going? Going out with friends? You have a wife!"

All of it, like ultrasound, shook me from the inside. The only places I could be myself were work and business trips. I didn't want to go home.

God, what a weakling I was! How did I, a man with normal core values, turn into such a person? Very simply – it happened gradually, almost imperceptibly. Scandals weren't that frequent; the rest of the time – love and forgiveness. I really loved her deeply, even told myself mentally at the start that I'd take all her sins upon myself (thoughts are material, my friends).

Then – pregnancy. The first, difficult one. The baby was born at seven months. There was hypoxia – resulted in cerebral palsy. I was so happy about our first child that I didn't understand the full scale of what had happened. Only my mother looked at me with horror, pain, and bitterness.

I don't want to talk about the hospitals, the attempts to "treat" cerebral palsy – that's not for you, that's my cross to bear. I pitied my Yulanka and tried to make her life as easy as possible. By then we had our own apartment. I became not only the breadwinner but also the housekeeper, nanny, and nurse. I'll say one thing: I was the first to hold our child and change his diaper.

Then came sleepless nights. After work, I'd come home and fully switch into household mode: cooked, washed dishes, cleaned, fed the baby with a bottle (traditional breastfeeding didn't work), then carried the baby in my arms almost all night until he finally fell asleep. Neurology – what can you do? My wife slept – she was tired after a whole day alone with the child. Sure, the grandmothers helped every other day, and I hired a nanny, but that doesn't erase a mother's exhaustion – it's really hard for her. And you still have to manage the grandmothers and the nanny (you can't boss my mother around, but you can twist your face in displeasure). It's hard work, really hard.

Now let me show you my home. Although I'm deeply ashamed, it's necessary for our work.

Over my life, I bought two apartments. First a one-bedroom where we lived when our first child was born, then a large three-bedroom apartment with two bathrooms and a walk-in closet. Bought them outright, no mortgage. The first at 27, the second at 29. But what united these two homes – good renovation, appliances (dishwasher, washing machine, dryer, etc.), furniture, and... an awful mess.

Yulanka loved buying "essential, useful, quality items that will come in handy later." The closets took the first hit; when space ran out, everything else was distributed across dressers, tables, and floors. Dirty dishes somehow refused to load themselves into the dishwasher; the "shameless" floors didn't wash themselves; and the impudent clothes didn't fold neatly onto shelves but preferred to lie wherever gravity pulled them. The kitchen table looked like a warehouse, and to eat, you first had to clear yourself a space. But it all took on a somewhat decent appearance when I, coming home from work, begged – and sometimes kicked – things into their designated places.

I'd stand in the kitchen, look at the mountains of dishes, and feel anger boiling inside me. I bought a dishwasher so I wouldn't have to wash by hand. But it stood empty, while the sink was clogged. I'd start washing, and with every motion I'd feel exhaustion filling me. Not from work – from doing it all over again, from knowing it would never end, from knowing no one saw me, no one would say "thank you." I felt invisible. I felt my work meant nothing. And at the same time I knew: if I didn't do it, no one would. So I did it. Because I was used to it. Because it had to be done. Because I was "good."

You'll say: "Well, you're a real henpecked husband, and you're here teaching us about life?! You devalued yourself and now you're trying to find excuses?!" My answer – at that moment, no. I became a complete henpecked husband later, but back then I was still resisting. What I did at home, with the stuff and everything else, I did for myself. I was used to living in a house where order and cleanliness were as integral as walls and ceilings. And I'm not looking for excuses or sympathy – I'm showing how it was and what led to that wild Gray Storm that almost swallowed me.

So, we've come to the moment where I'll finally start talking about two personalities in one person.

The first personality – that anchor that held me. The sweet, responsive, cheerful, loving girl I met and fell for at first sight.

The second – a rival, someone you have to fight constantly.

How it works. We live, we communicate, she "shines" on me – everything is great, idyllic. She purrs, tells me about her things, sometimes asks about what I'm doing, might bring me something tasty. We go for a walk with our child – I push the stroller, she walks alongside with a carefree look, cheerful, chattering. Passersby even turn and think: "What a happy family!"

But the moment I say something that goes against her opinion or her views on life – a storm hits! Her face changes, a wild fire appears in her eyes that burns from a distance, and her purr turns into a shout, a commanding tone, crashing down on me like a heavy, sticky wave of accusations.

Even when I go back to my "duties" as a housekeeper – cooking (I love good food, and in this situation, no matter how you spin it, you have to; she used to cook and it was tasty, but after the child was born it all vanished, and at best she'd make some exotic dish that makes me sick. "Don't like it? Cook for yourself") – she'd come over and throw in her two cents: "Why so sloppy? You should do it this way, and that way..."

That killed any desire I had to do anything.

You're reading these lines, and subconsciously you're thinking: "Yeah, buddy, you're a pathetic weakling, can't put your woman in her place, I don't even feel sorry for you!" Ask yourself, men: how often do you put your woman in her place? I'm not counting those men who have a natural egoism and a paradigm where women mean nothing – they have no problem with that, their women wouldn't dare. I'm talking about those who were raised the same way – as "good boys," given the rule that girls shouldn't be hurt or hit, that girls are future mothers, and you must obey your mother. I'm talking about those.

And so we've come to the main point – what I call "two personalities." This isn't schizophrenia. This isn't a "split" in the psyche. It's a survival mechanism that one person uses to control another.

The first personality is the anchor. That sweet, responsive, cheerful, loving girl I met at 22. She purrs, brings tasty things, walks beside the stroller and smiles at passersby. She is the one I cling to. She is the reason I endure. She is the justification for all my actions: "I love her, she's good, she's just tired, she's just growing up, just hormones, just..." That's the hook. Without that hook, I would have left. But the hook holds.

The second personality is the rival. She appears the moment I say or do something against her will. Her face changes, her eyes light up with wild fire, her voice turns into a commanding tone. She shouts, reproaches, accuses. She dishes out a portion of guilt – heavy, sticky, like tar. And that tar sticks. It doesn't let me breathe, think, resist. It makes me feel guilty for existing.

And here's what I realized years later. These two personalities don't live separately. They work as a pair. The first creates hope. The second punishes. The first gives me a reason to stay. The second makes me feel I have no right to leave. It's a perfect control system. And it works until I see its mechanism.

When I started seeing that mechanism, I stopped being a victim. I saw that my wife is not a "villain" nor an "angel." She's a person using the tools life gave her. She doesn't know any other way. And she's not to blame for me allowing her to do it. I am to blame. I allowed it.

The first sip was always the sweetest. The whiskey burns your throat, warmth spreads through your chest, thoughts stop being so sharp. For a few minutes, it gets easier. You close your eyes – and you're not here, you don't exist, you just disappear. But an hour later you wake up on the floor, your head splitting, bitterness in your mouth. And you hear her voice again: "You're nobody, you're worthless, you can't even quit drinking." And you reach for the bottle again. Drinking hurt. But not drinking hurt even more.

I allowed it, because I was "good." I allowed it because I was afraid of scandals. I allowed it because I wanted her to be happy. I allowed it because I didn't know I had the right to say "no." I didn't know that my refusal wasn't betrayal, but protection. I didn't know that my life wasn't a battlefield where I had to yield to keep the peace.

I know that now. And I'm writing this for those who don't know yet.

Here's what I've realized:

- Devaluation is not an accident. It's a tool. Some use it deliberately, some unconsciously. But the result is always the same: you stop being yourself.
- "Good" doesn't mean "always available." If you can't say "no" – you're not "good," you're "available." And availability isn't valued.
- Love is not an excuse. Love isn't about "enduring" and "forgiving." Love is about respect. If you're not respected – it's not love. It's dependency.

- The people close to you are not obligated to understand you. You are obligated to protect yourself. Even from them. Especially from them.
- If you don't set boundaries – they disappear. And then you disappear along with them.

The wife of an "Emperor" is an "Empress." But if the husband is a "Goat" – then the wife is also a "Goat."

At first, I didn't understand at all what was happening. I thought – girlish whims, she'll grow up, change. And she did change. Yulenska took over. Our life turned into a battlefield of two rivals. I didn't want to hurt her – I knew what that felt like. I pitied her. I gave in. And in the end, I lost the fight.

Only looking back did I see how it looked from the outside.

She wasn't a villainess. She was just doing what life and the family she grew up in taught her. Her mother behaved that way with her father. What example did she have? None other. And she did it unconsciously, as everyone does who doesn't know how else.

I don't want to whitewash her. I don't want to blame her. I want to tell the truth. She switched to control mode when she saw a weakness. She understood my immaturity. She screwed guilt into my brain like a self-tapping screw into wood. And I turned the screwdriver myself – every time I gave in, when I stayed silent, when I swallowed the resentment and told myself: "Well, she's tired, she's a woman."

She took my responsibility and made it her tool. Love for children – a lever. Fear of scandals – a hook. And I gave her those keys myself. I didn't notice how I became obedient. How I stopped being the master in my home, my life, my head.

I was immature. I lived in the old paradigm of my parents – a good boy. But I should have grown up! In business, I did that quickly – I was a spinner, darting around and biting off pieces of prey from grown, seasoned wolves. But I perceived my family as my mother's home – warm, cozy, where I was taken care of. But that was already my home. Where I had to become the master, not live in an illusory world. Instead, I handed over the reins. Voluntarily gave up the "symbol of power" to avoid hearing my wife's screams, which in fact were just a screen for her fears. She was waiting for action, and I was hiding. In the end, she took the helm herself.

It wasn't evil. It was a game. And I was the main player in it, without realizing it. Simply because I was afraid to say "no." Simply because I thought love meant enduring. Simply because I was a "good boy" who didn't know how to defend himself.

When I saw that – I stopped being a victim.

I think the roots of such relationships grow from family and school. Neither gives knowledge or skills for building harmonious relationships between spouses. Parents often don't know how to live together themselves. And school teaches all kinds of nonsense that will never

be useful in life, and doesn't teach the most important things – communication skills, interaction, practical life skills, without which a person can't live fully.

I'm not saying all women are like that. They're all different. I'm saying that I created this reality myself. And anyone who wants to see an accusation against all women in my text – is just looking for a place to hide from their own screw-ups.

Don't rush to blame your wife. Ask yourself: who gave her the remote?

Exercise for Chapter 2: "Who is speaking inside me?"

Write down three phrases your partner says to you when you disagree. Now write down what you say to yourself in response. Separate their voice from yours.

CHAPTER 3. THE REBEL AWAKENS



November 2014

Chapter 2 ended with me seeing the system. I saw how devaluation works. I saw two personalities – the one I held onto, and the one that was destroying me. I saw that I had given permission for it myself.

But seeing the system doesn't mean you're out of it. That's only the first step.

The next step was scarier. I had to admit that I wasn't just a "victim of circumstances." I was an accomplice. I allowed it. I agreed. I swallowed it. I kept shifting the boundaries until they disappeared. I built that cage I was sitting in myself.

And when I realized that, the rebel who had always been inside me woke up. The one I'd pushed deep down because he got in the way of me being a "good boy." The one who said: "This is not your life. You don't have to endure this. You have the right to say 'no.'"

I didn't give him a voice for a long time. I was afraid of him. I thought that if I let him speak, I'd become bad, evil, selfish. I thought I'd lose love, family, respect. I thought I'd end up alone.

But I was already alone. I was alone in my pain, in my fear, in my bottle. I was alone even when people were around. And I realized: it can't get worse than what I already feel. And if it can't get worse – then I can take a risk.

I took the risk. I gave my rebel a voice. And he said what I was afraid to hear: "You are not a victim. You are a creator. And you have the right to build your life the way you want."

That was the first step toward freedom. And it was the hardest, or so it seemed to me then. Only the scariest part turned out to be something else – forgetting and relaxing.

There were moments when our life flowed smoothly. Like driving on a straight highway in summer: heat, sun shining, occasional minor potholes and seams. Little spats and trivial scandals – and they always started over nonsense: loading the wrong laundry into the washing machine, or buying the wrong cherries. I quickly got used to the good times. Because in those moments my Yulanka was "real." I'd shut the rebel up and enjoy the rare sunny days.

But time passed – and like clockwork, my "fuck-ups" and unfulfilled assignments would pile up again. Or rather, unexecuted orders. The sun would give way to a storm, and the storm would hit.

The longer this went on (by then we had three children), the longer my recovery took. Earlier, when the kids were small, I'd hide from the storm in business trips. Or in the summer I'd send the whole crew to Crimea – providing money, housing, and transport (she drives well, I trained her well). I'd run away from the family – either home or on a business trip – to feel like myself, free from pressure, instead of restructuring my mindset and fixing my family life.

Not because I was a fool or a henpecked husband. But because back then I had no idea that you could do that. Sure, the internet existed where you could find the right information, but for me it was empty. Because I didn't know how to learn back then. I didn't know how to analyze myself.

My rebel was doing his job. My subconscious was screaming: "This can't go on! Divorce her, leave!"

And what would have happened then? I see it now. I'd start drinking for joy (by that time it had become a habit – an anesthesia that threatened to grow into a serious addiction). I'd have more money left. And I'd find myself exactly the same kind of woman. Maybe even tougher than Yulenska.

Because the problem wasn't her. The problem was me. My beliefs. My habit of enduring. My inability to say "no." My fear of being bad.

I could change the woman, but I wouldn't change myself. And that meant the story would repeat. Again "sunny days," again the storm, again the bottle, again the escape. Again.

That realization didn't come to me right away. It matured over years. But when it came – I understood that my rebel had to wake up not to destroy the family. He had to wake up to rebuild me. To start with myself. Not with her.

We lived like that for thirty years, but the hardest were the last five. To move forward, I need to dive into certain moments of my life – without that, the puzzle pieces won't fit. I need to tell how we lived, how I lived, and what I did in and for the family.

I already mentioned: we have a decent apartment, and also a decent dacha. In 2014, our third child was born, and my wife declared that we needed to renovate the apartment. Yes, the renovation was needed by then. But at that time I had a small financial dip, plus the birth of the child, and a buddy from Crimea showed up out of nowhere – he came looking for work and lived with us for a month until I helped him with his papers and found him a job. I barely got him out – had to rent a room for him.

My softness and her persistence met again. I said: "Let's take all the stuff and furniture from the apartment to a storage facility. It's easier and faster to renovate an empty apartment, and we can live at the dacha in the meantime."

"What do you mean, at the dacha? What about my things? They'll get ruined, stolen! – she screamed. – Are you out of your mind? Are you an idiot? If you're stupid – go get your head checked!"

And... I gave in again.

I heard her voice. Saw her face. Knew she was wrong. But something clenched inside. I couldn't say "no." I was afraid – if I did, there'd be a week-long scandal. I was afraid she'd stop loving me. I was afraid of being "bad." And I gave in. Again. I heard the rebel go quiet inside. I heard him say: "You're doing it again. You're allowing it again. You're choosing her over yourself again." But I shut him up. Being "good" was more familiar than being myself.

Around that time, I landed a good contract for a decent sum, but the deadlines were extremely tight, and I didn't want to waste my nerves and be in a shattered state. I had to get the

job done, and that required full concentration and energy. The contract was from a state corporation, and missing the deadline would have serious consequences.

I hired two Uzbek Tajiks (great guys, educated, brothers, and professionals in their trade). We agreed on price and terms, I gave them an advance, and they got to work. I don't know who I felt more sorry for in that situation – Bakhtiyar and his brother, or us? Doing a full renovation in an apartment crammed with furniture and junk – let me tell you, what a pleasure! With the kitchen out of commission, cooking moved to the large bathroom, and meals – wherever we could find space. Don't forget about a disabled child and a newborn. This went on for three months. Thank God I spent most of my time at work, and my Yulenska... I think she was even comfortable in that chaos.

I realized that later. The chaos in the house – it's not an accident. It's a method of control. When there's mess around you, you can't relax. Always on edge. Always having to do something. Always guilty. And in that chaos, she is the only one who knows "how it should be." You clean, wash, carry, fix. And she watches and tells you you're doing it wrong. Chaos is a weapon. And she wielded it masterfully.

In the middle of the third month, I had to leave for a large Siberian city. The state corporation was holding an exhibition there, and our product was the main exhibit (I'll tell you in



secret: even Putin walked around it for about ten minutes, carefully examining our model). The work was very serious and responsible: deliver, assemble, fine-tune, then disassemble and send back to Petersburg. The product – nine meters long and three meters wide. A highway with thirty little cars driving along it, towns, villages, fields, lakes – everything controlled by electronics that refused to work properly before the start. But we prevailed – Putin was pleased!

I was drained. Not just tired – I was empty. Inside, there was no emotion left, no strength, no desire to feel anything. I checked into a hotel room, lay down on the bed, and stared at the ceiling. I just wanted to lie there. Two days. Do nothing. Listen to no one. Not answer calls. Just exist.

I knew that if I went home – a scandal was waiting for me. I knew it a hundred percent. But I was so exhausted that I decided: let there be a scandal. I don't care. I just want to be alone.

So on the second morning, I'm lying in the hotel, staring at the ceiling, thinking: "Good. Quiet. No one yelling. No one demanding." And then – the phone rings. I recognized her number right away.

The phone rang. That knot tightened inside again. I don't want to pick up. I want to tell myself: "I'm not at home, I'm on a business trip, I deserve a rest." But I pick up. Because I can't not pick up. I know – if I don't, it'll be worse.

At first she spoke sweetly: "Honey, when are you coming back?" I answered: "I need to stay a couple more days, I'm tired, I need to rest." And she exploded: "Are you out of your fucking mind?! Stay longer?! I'm here alone with your children! And your workers are asking me all kinds of questions! Get your ass home now!..."

I listened. I didn't interrupt. I stared at the wall and listened. And at some point I realized – I wasn't angry. I wasn't offended. I just felt emptiness. Not rage. Not pain. Emptiness.

I had done work I was proud of. I stood a few meters away from the president. And I was being dragged through the mud for wanting to rest.

I couldn't take it. I hung up. Then my new Samsung flew into the wall. I looked at the pieces and felt only one thing: "This is not my life. I don't want to live like this."

I packed my things, got in the car, and drove to the dacha. I didn't want to go home. I knew there would be hell there. I knew she would scream. I wanted to be alone. I wanted to drink. Not to forget – but to feel something other than emptiness.

I arrived at the dacha. I grabbed a bottle. And I drank. For the first time in a long time, I wasn't drinking out of grief – I was drinking from the realization that my life wasn't my own. I drank because I didn't know how to change it.

I spent four days at the dacha. She called – I didn't answer. On the fourth day, she showed up herself. I walked out into the yard. She stood by the car, looked at me, and said: "Well, hello there, drunkard! I see you can't do without a bottle, have you pickled your brains completely? Where's the money?!"



Behind her sat our child – he was eleven. She turned to him and said: "Look, your beloved dad is drinking. And you, you little brat, you still defend him! Don't bother coming back home, I'm filing for divorce."

I looked at her. I felt nothing. I just looked. Then I turned and walked back into the house. They drove away. I stayed.

In the morning, I washed up, shaved, combed my hair, and drove home. I knew there would be a scandal. But I decided: I won't make excuses. I won't apologize. I'll just say what I think.

I opened the door. Yulanka was standing in the kitchen, smiling as if nothing had happened. She said: "I'm so exhausted with your children, you have no idea!" I looked at her. I was silent. Then I said: "I'm tired too. I'm tired of you."

She fell silent. I didn't wait for an answer. I just walked into the kitchen, made some tea, sat down at the table, and started thinking. For the first time, I asked myself: "What if I'm not supposed to change her? What if I'm supposed to change myself?"

That question was scarier than all the scandals put together. Because changing her – that's easy. I could blame her, hate her, demand things from her. But changing myself – that meant admitting I was wrong. That I didn't just "allow" it – I created this system. I gave her power over me.

I realized: no one can devalue you until you give them permission. I did. Every time I moved the line. Every time I made excuses for her behavior. Every time I forgave without receiving an apology. Every time I stayed silent.

I decided: I won't be silent anymore. I didn't know how to do it. But I decided to start.

Exercise for Chapter 3: "Your First 'No'"

Remember a situation when you kept quiet even though you wanted to say "no." Write down what you would have said if you could go back. Now imagine that situation repeats tomorrow. What will you say?

CHAPTER 4. "THE DETOUR. HOW I CHOSE MYSELF"



July 2026

Yesterday we went to the beach. At the exit from the ring road, there was a massive traffic jam in our direction. I decided to take the detour – forty kilometers longer, but moving instead of standing still.

We made it to the long-awaited bay. White sand, pine trees, family, sea, sun – how great it is to spend a weekend by the sea with your family! We swam, sunbathed, paddled with the youngest on a SUP. I grilled meat on the barbecue. Idyllic.

The oldest child, the one with disabilities, lay on a specially spread blanket and was very content.

Evening came. We packed up, and I headed to the car to load the trunk. At the parking lot, I chatted with some people who had just arrived and found out: toward Petersburg, from Lebyazhye to the ring road – a huge traffic jam, at least fifteen kilometers. It was a hot day, lots of people had gone to the beach, and now all of them were heading back to the city. I knew that road – you could be stuck for hours, with no alternative route.

I told my wife: "We'll take the detour, the way we came – and we won't be sitting in traffic."

She snorted: "Let's just go that way, it'll clear up."

I said: "No. It's a jam from Lebyazhye to the ring road. I don't want to sit in traffic. We're taking the detour."

I didn't argue. I just made the decision. And I was right – we drove without a single traffic jam. The road was clear.

She looked at me with a smirk: "Does my opinion mean nothing? Why do you decide which way we go?!"

I looked at her and calmly said: "Because I'm a man. And I know better how and where we should go."

She smirked with a cocky grin: "What, ha-ha, a man?! Sure, sure. Well, I wanted to go that way!"

She sat in silence the whole way, turned away. And I was silent too. Didn't make excuses, didn't prove anything. Just drove. Knowing I was right.

We got home without any traffic jams. I was carrying the oldest on my shoulder. Behind me walked the youngest – he's eleven. Then my wife. I opened the entrance door, went in, the youngest behind me. I said: "Hold the door for your mom, she doesn't have keys." He snorted: "She can wait" – and walked into the house. Their relationship is bad – she constantly nitpicks him for no reason. I can no longer explain to him that he should respect and obey his mother, because my wife herself escalates things, then shifts the blame and responsibility onto me: "Go discipline your child, hit him!" – she says. I reply: "When he was rude to me, I walked up silently and gave him a cuff on the head – he hasn't been rude since. Do the same, instead of just making noise. He's rude to you – it's a conflict between you two. And I'm supposed to resolve it and ruin my relationship with him? I don't yell or punish without reason. That's on you."

The child was wrong. At home, I told him again that he should go and open the door for his mother. But his resentment toward her – for the nagging, for the ruined outing – took over, and he went to his room. I was still carrying the oldest, who isn't light, and couldn't stand there holding him while waiting for the "haymaking" to end.

I laid the oldest on the bed and went back to the car for the bags. Meanwhile, my wife had gotten into the building. Someone opened the entrance door – and it started!

She threw a scandal – about the youngest, about me doing things my way, about not taking the road she wanted. "I support this family! – she yelled. – And you should drive the way I tell you and do what I say! If you can't provide for us!"



I couldn't take it. I said calmly: "Are you out of your fucking mind, my dear? I'll drive and do things the way I see fit. I have logical, rational thinking, unlike your 'I want it this way and that's it.' And if you're talking nonsense – I'll tell you. And if you're providing – then provide. Maybe you're the one feeding the oldest, changing his diapers, taking care of him?"

I continued: "I bust my ass for you here – driving, cooking – and I'm still always the guilty one. And where do you live? In an apartment I bought without a mortgage. You use things and a car that I bought. So here's the situation: go ahead and provide, until I get back on my feet. I'm up at five in the morning to work. Then I drive you to the beach. And instead of gratitude – buckets of shit and reproaches. Why don't you go fuck yourself!"

I wasn't shouting. I was just talking. And I felt everything inside falling into place.

I don't know what will happen next. But I know: I will no longer be the one who swallows it all. I will no longer be the one who endures. I will no longer be the one who makes excuses.

I asked her then: "Why do you women think that after a stamp in the passport, a man becomes your eternal servant and slave? You came with nothing. In the old days, there was a dowry. I gave you everything I have. And I have the right to ask and demand things from you. I have the right to fuck another woman if you're not giving it to me, but only fucking with my head. I have the right to tell you what to do when you go off the rails. I'm not a tyrant and I'm not an abuser. I'm only asking for the basics: respect (which doesn't exist), care (twenty-eighty here), sex (lately three times at most, before that it was a long dry spell). And don't pick at my brain (you pick at it constantly)."

I said it not with resentment. With confidence.

I made a choice. I chose myself.

I don't know if the children will stay with me. I don't know if she'll be around in a year. But I know one thing: I will no longer live in a system where I'm devalued, where my work goes unnoticed, where boundaries aren't respected and my nerves are constantly frayed.

She has to change herself. I won't wait, persuade, or endure. If she wants to – she'll change. If not – I'm ready to move on alone.

Because I want to stay clean. Not in a moral sense. In the sense of choice. I don't want to get dirty in her game. I don't want to argue, prove, make excuses. I want to build my life. And if she wants to be part of it – she'll have to change. If not – I'm ready to move on.

I am not a victim. I am the master of my own life. I choose to be clean.

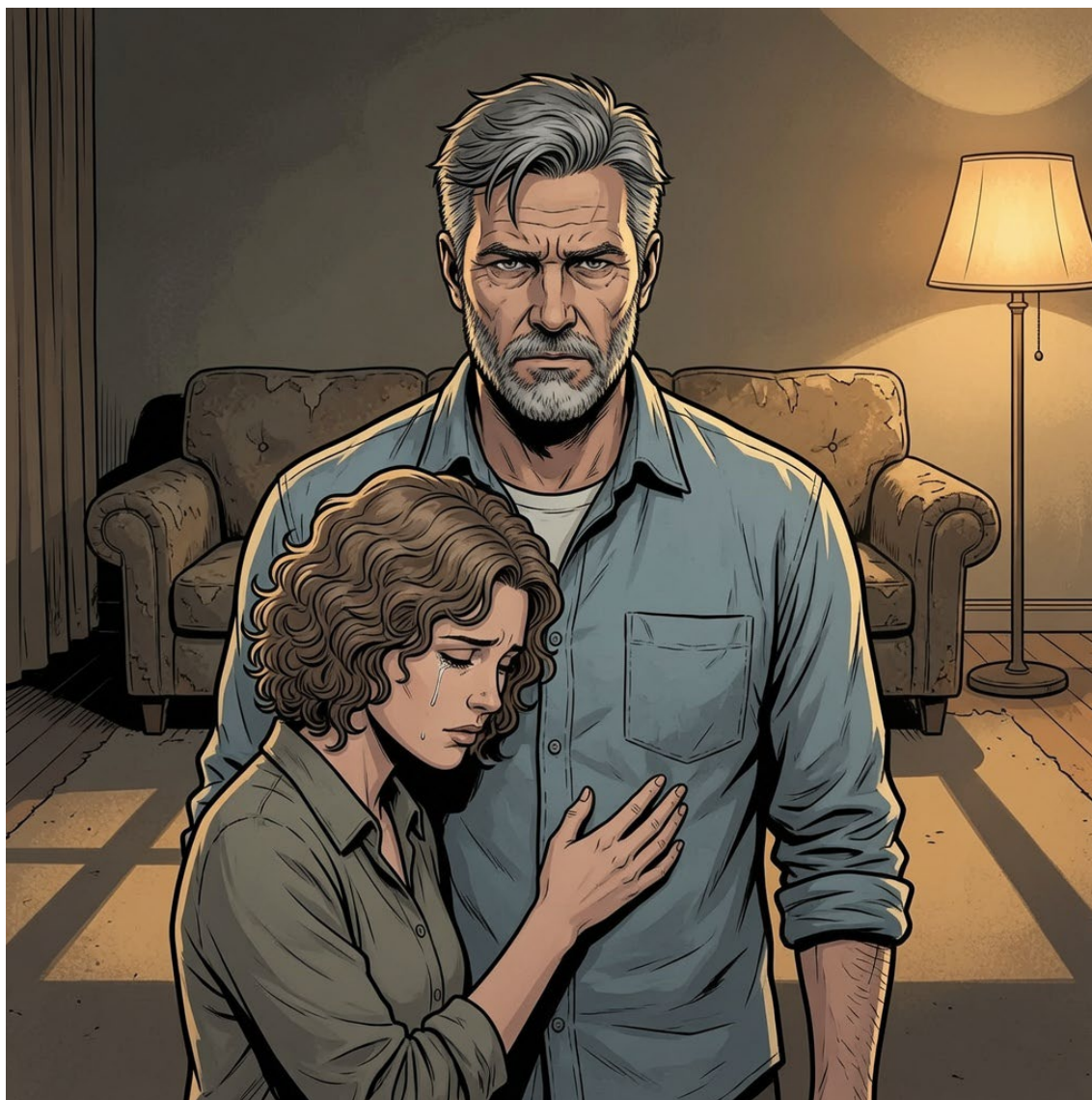
The result wasn't long in coming.

In the morning I was sitting at my computer – I get up early, at five or six in the morning, so no one can disturb my work. I thought she was still asleep. But then the door opens, and Yulenska walks in – meek, with a gentle smile.

She came over and hugged me tenderly: "How are you doing, working? Maybe we should go back to bed for a while?"

I answered that I still hadn't finished my work plan for today, and I needed to finish before our next trip to the beach. And I asked: "So, are we taking the detour today?"

She looked at me warmly, without reproach: "Whatever you say. Of course we will. There are such beautiful views there, I want to take some photos."



I understood – something had changed.

But I didn't melt like I used to. I remembered the previous evening – the scandal, her shouting, my words. And I was even ready for a new one. Inside, there was only one feeling: I didn't bend.

I don't care about her opinion on the route. I did what was right, as a man. Now it's her turn to behave like a woman.

And she did – exactly the way I always wanted: feminine, affectionate, without shouting.

I don't know how long this will last – a day, a week, a year. But I know one thing: I will never go back to that cage. I will no longer be a victim. I will not bend.

I choose peace, respect, intimacy. But I choose them not as a "reward" for enduring, but as the result of honesty.

I don't know if she'll change. But I know that I have changed. And that's the main thing.

Exercise for Chapter "The Detour": "My Boundaries"

Write down what things you are no longer willing to tolerate in a relationship. This will be your list of boundaries.

CHAPTER 5. A PLAN FOR ONE YEAR AND TEN YEARS



We've come a long way. We've broken down how the devaluation system works, how to get out of the Gray Storm, how to build boundaries, how to earn, save, and invest. Now only one

thing remains – to put it all into a plan. Without a plan, knowledge is just information. With a plan, it becomes action.

I know what I'm talking about. I didn't have a plan. I lived by inertia. I thought that "everything would work out somehow." I was wrong. When I made a plan – for the first time in my life – my life changed. Not immediately. Not in a month. But I started to see where I was going. And that gave me the strength not to break down when everything around me was falling apart.

Why a plan is not a limitation, but freedom

Most people know what they need to do. They know they need to save money. They know they need to learn. They know they need to change jobs. They know they need to set boundaries. But they don't do it. Why? Because they don't have a plan. They have "wants," but no road map. Without a road map, you don't know where to go. You just spin your wheels.

A plan is not a limitation. It's freedom. It's a route that shows where you're going and how long it will take. It's protection against chaos. It's a support system on difficult days. When I looked at the ashes of my workshop, I didn't have a plan. But when I stopped waiting for a miracle and started taking action, the plan emerged on its own. Not from my head – from life. I understood: if I don't know where I'm going, I'll never get there.



My freedom number: 300,000 rubles per month (\$3,448)

I used to think that 80,000 rubles (\$920) a month was freedom. I was wrong. 80,000 is survival. It's when you can cover your basic expenses, but you can't afford proper treatment, proper education for your children, proper rest. It's when you're still counting pennies at the end of the month. It's when one car breakdown or a child's illness knocks you off course.

I want to live, not just survive. I want my children to study where they want. I want health to be under control. I want to travel, help loved ones, invest in new projects. I want to be able to choose – whether to work or not, who to work with, what to work on.

300,000 rubles a month – that's not luxury. That's freedom. That's when you stop counting rubles. That's when you can say "no" to a client who doesn't respect you. That's when you can take a pause and not fear not being able to pay for your apartment.

How I calculated this number

I took my basic expenses – 56,500 rubles (\$650) per month. This is food, utilities, gasoline, workshop rent, basic medications. Then I added what life ceases to be life without:

Basic expenses	–	56,500	₽	(\$650)
Health (treatment for a disabled child, dentistry, insurance)	–	30,000	₽	(\$345)
Children's education (school, clubs, tutors, university)	–	40,000	₽	(\$460)
Travel (at least 2 trips per year)	–	25,000	₽	(\$287)
Helping loved ones (parents, brother)	–	15,000	₽	(\$172)
Savings and investments (to grow capital)	–	50,000	₽	(\$575)
Unforeseen expenses (car breakdown, urgent repairs)	–	30,000	₽	(\$345)
Living with a buffer (so you don't count pennies) – 53,500 ₽ (\$615)				

Total: 300,000 ₽ per month (\$3,448).

This isn't "I want everything at once." This is a realistic plan that allows you to live with dignity and not fear tomorrow. This is the amount at which you can breathe.

The capital I need

With a conservative yield of 10% per year, I need:

$$300,000 \times 12 = 3,600,000 \text{ rubles per year}$$
$$3,600,000 / 0.1 = 36,000,000 \text{ rubles } (\$414,000)$$

36 million rubles. That's my freedom number. Is it scary? Yes. Is it achievable? Also yes. If you build the system step by step: assets, equipment, digital products, real estate, intellectual property. If you add 2–3 new sources of income every year. If you don't withdraw the returns, but reinvest.

Calculation examples for different starting amounts

Many people think: "I don't have 36 million, so I'll never be free." That's a mistake. Freedom is built gradually. I'll show you how it works, using four examples – from zero to a million.

Starting from zero: is it realistic?

Yes. I started from negative myself – debts, loss of business, no savings. But I started small: I bought a laser machine with my last money, took orders, reinvested the profits. After 10 years, I reached a stable income. It's not fast. It's honest.

In the first year, saving 15,000 ₺ (\$172) per month, you'll accumulate 198,000 ₺ (\$2,276) with interest.

In the second year, increasing your contribution to 20,000 ₺ (\$230) per month, your capital will grow to 481,800 ₺ (\$5,538).

In the third year, saving 25,000 ₺ (\$287), you'll reach 859,980 ₺ (\$9,884).

In the fourth year – 30,000 ₺ (\$345) per month will give you 1,342,000 ₺ (\$15,425).

In the fifth year – 35,000 ₺ (\$402) will become 1,938,000 ₺ (\$22,276).

And after ten years, if you save 50,000 ₺ (\$575) per month, your capital will be around 6,000,000 ₺ (\$68,966).

That's not 36 million, but it's already serious capital that generates 50–60 thousand rubles (\$575–690) of passive income per month. That's enough to stop fearing tomorrow.

Starting with 100,000 rubles (\$1,149): how to accelerate

If you already have a small cushion – say, 100,000 rubles – you can start faster. Buy a used 3D printer, upload several models to marketplaces, get your first orders. Or invest in dividend stocks.

Starting capital: 100,000 ₺ (\$1,149).

After one year, saving 20,000 ₺ (\$230) per month, you'll reach 372,000 ₺ (\$4,276).

In the second year, increasing your contribution to 25,000 ₺ (\$287), your capital will grow to 734,200 ₺ (\$8,439).

In the third year – 30,000 ₺ (\$345) per month will give you 1,200,620 ₺ (\$13,800).

In the fourth – 35,000 ₺ (\$402) = 1,775,682 ₺ (\$20,410).

In the fifth – 40,000 ₺ (\$460) = 2,473,250 ₺ (\$28,428).

After ten years, with a contribution of 50,000 ₺ (\$575) per month, you'll reach around 8,500,000 ₺ (\$97,701).

That's already almost a third of the way to freedom. And if you continue – after 15 years it'll be 18 million (\$206,897), after 20 – 36 million (\$413,793).

Starting with 500,000 rubles (\$5,747): a fast start

If you have 500,000 rubles in free cash – that's already starting capital you can put to work. For example: buy a garage for 350,000 ₺ (\$4,023), rent it out for 10,000 ₺ (\$115) per month. Put the rest into stocks or equipment. This will give you both income and capital growth.

Starting capital: 500,000 ₺ (\$5,747).

After one year, saving 30,000 ₺ (\$345) per month, you'll reach 946,000 ₺ (\$10,874).

In the second year – 35,000 ₺ (\$402) will give you 1,495,600 ₺ (\$17,191).

In the third – 40,000 ₺ (\$460) = 2,265,160 ₺ (\$26,036).

In the fourth – 45,000 ₺ (\$517) = 3,256,676 ₺ (\$37,433).

In the fifth – 50,000 ₺ (\$575) = 4,232,344 ₺ (\$48,647).

After ten years, saving 60,000 ₺ (\$690) per month, you'll reach around 13,500,000 ₺ (\$155,172).

That's already close to your freedom number. And after 15 years – 25–28 million (\$287,356–\$321,839). If you continue – by year 20 you'll reach 36 million (\$413,793).

Starting with 1,000,000 rubles (\$11,494)

If you have 1 million rubles – you're already halfway there. You can buy 2–3 garages or parking spaces, or invest in equipment and start production. The main thing is not to keep your money in a savings account, but to put it to work.

Starting capital: 1,000,000 ₺ (\$11,494).

After one year, saving 40,000 ₺ (\$460) per month, you'll reach 1,628,000 ₺ (\$18,713).

In the second year – 50,000 ₺ (\$575) will give you 2,440,800 ₺ (\$28,055).

In the third – 60,000 ₺ (\$690) = 3,464,880 ₺ (\$39,826).

In the fourth – 70,000 ₺ (\$805) = 4,721,368 ₺ (\$54,269).

In the fifth – 80,000 ₺ (\$920) = 6,241,505 ₺ (\$71,741).

After ten years, saving 100,000 ₺ (\$1,149) per month, you'll reach around 22,000,000 ₺ (\$252,874).

After 10 years – 22 million (\$252,874). That leaves 14 million (\$160,920) to go. Another 5 years – and you're at the finish line.

The main takeaway from these calculations:

It doesn't matter how much you have right now – 0, 100 thousand, or 1 million. What matters is starting. Every year you delay saving costs you tens of thousands of rubles in lost income. Time is your most important resource. And the sooner you start, the sooner you'll reach freedom.

How I plan to reach 36 million rubles (\$414,000)

I broke the goal into stages. Not a "magical plan," but concrete steps I can check and measure.

Stage 1: Base income (0–3 years)

Goal: reach a stable income of 150,000 rubles (\$1,724) per month (active + passive).

What I'm doing:

- Finish and publish the book "The Path of the Phoenix."
- Create a website and launch sales.
- Set up a Telegram bot and Gumroad for automatic sales.
- Continue making models and 3D printing.
- Rent out the garage and the Volga.

Stage 2: Acceleration (3–6 years)

Goal: reach an income of 300,000 rubles (\$3,448) per month.

What I'm doing:

- Create digital products (prompt packages, 3D models, courses).
- Invest in equipment (new machines, printers).
- Buy another asset (garage, parking space, real estate).
- Enter the international market (book in English, Chinese).
- Hire assistants (designer, manager, video editor).

Stage 3: Freedom (6–10 years)

Goal: capital of 36 million rubles (\$414,000), passive income of 300,000 rubles (\$3,448) per month.

What I'm doing:

- Reinvest profits from assets.
- Scale digital products.

- Create a model-makers' school or online course.
- Enter new markets (Europe, Asia).
- Start investing in startups and other people's projects.

Five rules I gave myself

When I understood how much I needed and where I was going, I formulated five strict rules for myself. They're not for everyone. They're for those ready to get out of the rat race. Here they are.

1. Forget about "finding a good job."

A job is a ceiling. You trade your time for a salary that melts by the end of the month. You can work – absolutely, you should work. But build something of your own. Something that will bring income even when you're asleep. A job gives you money. Your own business gives you freedom.

2. Find one skill people are willing to pay for.

And pour all your free time into it. Maybe you know how to build websites. Maybe you can consult. Maybe you can do repairs, write books, or 3D print. Don't spread yourself thin. One skill. Perfect it. Make people line up for it.

3. Don't spend the first money.

It's not income. It's seed. Set it aside and don't touch it until you've accumulated enough to buy your first asset. Don't withdraw the returns. Don't buy "that cool thing." The first money isn't for living. It's for starting.

4. Cut out everything unnecessary for at least a year.

No trinkets. No restaurants. No expensive new clothes. No vacations on your last dime. One year of discipline can change the next ten to fifteen years. One year. You can handle it. I did.

5. Stop listening to advice from people who haven't achieved anything.

Advice without results is noise. Garbage. Find one person whose path you want to follow. Watch what they do. Learn from them. Not from a hundred couch experts. From one who's walked that path.

Wealth is a system. Those who learn and understand it will recover even from ashes. Those who don't will remain forever in the rat race.

Three scenarios: where you could be in 10 years

Scenario 1: "I keep working the way I do now"

You don't build capital. You live paycheck to paycheck. You don't invest. You don't grow. In 10 years, you'll have the same salary (less with inflation), the same debts, the same problems. You're tired, but not free. You work because you have to. This isn't life – it's survival.

Scenario 2: "I build a system"

You create sources of passive income. You invest in equipment, skills, assets. You grow every year. In 10 years, you have capital that generates 300,000 rubles (\$3,448) per month. You are free. You can choose – whether to work or not, who to work with, what to work on.

Scenario 3: "I become an investor"

You don't sell time. You sell solutions. You invest in projects, people, ideas. You manage capital, not work for it. In 10 years, you're not just free – you create freedom for others. You are the captain of your life and the lives of those around you.

Turning points: when everything changes

There are moments in life when you make the most important decisions. They change everything. I've been through them. And I know: every time I chose action – I won.

Turning point 1. Crisis. When everything falls apart, you can either give up or start over. I chose to start over. Every time.

Turning point 2. Job loss. When you're left without income, you can either panic or look for new opportunities. I looked. And I found.

Turning point 3. Money appears. When money comes to you, you can either spend it or invest it. I invested. Not always. But I learned.

Turning point 4. An idea appears. When an idea comes to you, you can either forget it or start acting. I started acting. And that led me to where I am now.

What my plan looks like in practice

Annual plan (Year 1):

- Finish and publish the book "The Path of the Phoenix" (e-book and print).
- Create a website and launch sales (landing page + Telegram bot).
- Set up automatic sales through Gumroad.
- Write 10–15 articles on Zen to build an audience.
- Create the first 3–5 3D models and upload them to Cults3D and TurboSquid.
- Find at least one assistant (designer, video editor, manager).
- Reach a passive income of 150,000 rubles (\$1,724) per month.

Ten-year plan:

- Capital of 36 million rubles (\$414,000).
- Complete freedom – work only if I want to.
- Travel with family, educate children, develop the workshop.
- Create a model-makers' school or online course.
- Enter the international market (book in English and Chinese).
- Invest in other people's projects (angel investing).

What I understood when I made the plan

I understood that a plan is not about the future. It's about the present. When you have a plan, you stop flailing. You know what you're doing today, tomorrow, in a year. You're not afraid of crises – you expect them and prepare for them. You're not afraid of mistakes – you correct them. You're not afraid of life – you build it.

I didn't always execute the plan perfectly. But I always came back to it. It kept me on course when I wanted to give up. It reminded me that I'm not a victim. I'm a creator. And my plan is my blueprint.

Now it's your turn.

Exercise for Chapter 5: "Three Plans"

Take a piece of paper. Write:

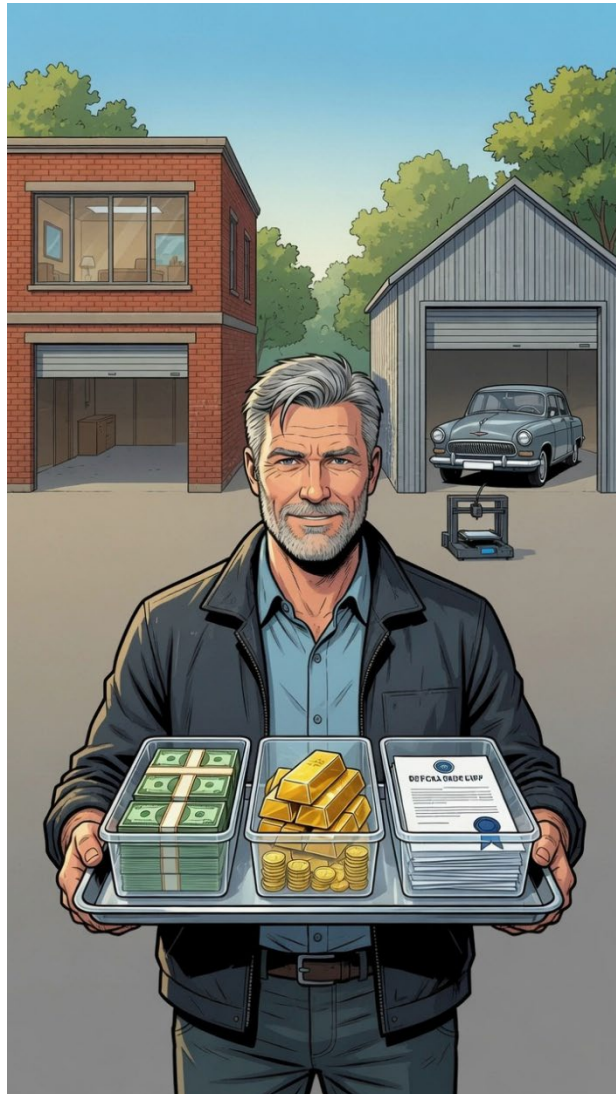
Plan	1:	Annual.
One goal. 12 steps. Each month – one step.		

Plan	2:	Ten-year.
Three scenarios. One choice. One direction.		

Plan	3:	Turning	points.
Crisis, job loss, money appears, an idea appears. What will you do at each turning point?			

Don't put it off. Do it now. A plan is a map. And without a map, you don't know where you're going.

CHAPTER 6. MY FINANCIAL SYSTEM



This chapter brings together the previous sections about money to avoid repetition and give a clear, holistic picture.

I read Goldstein's book. I took what works from it and discarded what doesn't work in 2026. His "three pockets" system is logical and correct. But he wrote in a different time, under different conditions. In 2026, banks write off money for debts, inflation eats away at interest, and savings accounts have ceased to be reliable. I learned this the hard way – I put money in an account, it was written off under enforcement proceedings; I saved – inflation ate half. I did everything I was taught – and I lost. I needed my own system.

Survival Budget (First Pocket)

This is the base level: food, housing, utilities, gasoline, communication – everything you can't survive a month without. I recorded all expenses honestly, down to the penny. During the period when I was just getting back on my feet:

- Utilities – 18,000 ₺ (\$207) on average.
- Gasoline – 15,000 ₺ (\$172) (500 ₺/day × 30).
- Food – 11,000 ₺ (\$126) (at work we cooked in a slow cooker, for three people – 340–400 ₺/day).
- Medications and child-related expenses – 2,500 ₺ (\$29).
- Workshop rent – 10,000 ₺ (\$115).

****Total – 56,500 ₺ (\$650) per month.**** Pension and benefits – 51,000 ₺ (\$586). A deficit of 5,500 ₺ (\$63) per month that I had to earn on top just to cover basic expenses. And I did earn them – first with the laser machine (15–30 thousand, or \$172–345), then with 3D printing, infographics, websites. The first pocket is sacred. You never touch it. Under no circumstances.

Asset Protection (Second Pocket)

This is where I diverged from Goldstein. He recommends a savings account or deposit. In 2026, that's risky – the bank can write off money for debts, a court can seize it, inflation will eat the interest. I store the second pocket like this:

1. **Physical gold** – I bought several Nikolaev gold coins (7.5 g, 900 fineness) at 30–35,000 rubles (\$345–402) each. They can't be written off, they don't lose value as quickly.
2. **Cash in different currencies** – dollars, euros, rubles – stored at home. No one knows about it, not even my wife.
3. **Garages and a vintage car** – living assets.
 - The first garage (with a pit, storage room, wood-paneled, with a lounge area) I bought for 450,000 ₺ (\$5,172) in Sosnovy Bor, rent it out for 18,000 ₺ (\$207)/month. Paid for itself in 2 years.
 - The second, a metal one, for 189,000 ₺ (\$2,172) – it houses an antique Volga.
 - The Volga I bought for 250,000 ₺ (\$2,874) – cars like this only appreciate. I rent it out for weddings, photoshoots, corporate events (2,500 ₺/hour, minimum order 2 hours = 5,000 ₺, or \$57). 3–4 orders a month – another 15–20 thousand (\$172–230). At first I drove it myself, now I've found an enthusiastic young guy – he drives, maintains the car, and gets a percentage.

Growth (Third Pocket)

Goldstein says: start investing as early as possible. I say: don't rush. Investing without protection is a risk. First, build a cushion, pay off expensive debts – then think about growth.

My third pocket is **equipment**.

- Laser machine (80,000 ₺, or \$920) paid for itself in 10 months, brings in 15–30 thousand (\$172–345)/month.
- 3D printers (three units at 25–35 thousand each, or \$287–402) run around the clock. The main work is models (cities, railways, buildings, landscapes) – that's my specialization. The printers print parts for models and third-party orders, bringing in an additional 10–40 thousand (\$115–460)/month.

Passive streams – my ladder

I'm not building "passive income" in the sense that gurus sell it. I'm building a ladder.

- **Step 1:** Active income (hands, head).
- **Step 2:** Equipment that works for me (machine, printers).
- **Step 3:** Physical assets (garages, Volga).
- **Step 4:** Digital products (book, course – made once, sold many times).
- **Step 5:** Intellectual property (trademarks, patents, royalties) – I'm already starting to register my brand.
- **Step 6:** Capital that works – I haven't reached it yet, but I'm on my way.

In practice: safety cushion – 340,000 ₺ (\$3,908) (6 months of living expenses). Stored in gold, cash, assets. Garages bring in 18,000 ₺ (\$207)/month, the Volga – 15–20 thousand (\$172–230) in season, printers – 10–40 thousand (\$115–460), the machine – 15–30 thousand (\$172–345). Total – about 80,000 ₺ (\$920) per month in stable, predictable flow. Not millions, but they're mine – I know how to earn them and protect them.

Exercise for Chapter 6: "My Assets"

Write down what assets you currently have (what brings in money). Now write down what assets you can create in the next year – equipment, skills, real estate.

CHAPTER 7. "THE PHOENIX'S FIERY WINGS"



I stood on the ashes. Where just yesterday my workshop had been – now there was only smoke, scorched walls, and ash. Everything I had rebuilt over the years burned down in one night. Models, tools, machines, materials – all of it vanished. Only I remained. And the children. And emptiness.

It wasn't just a fire. It was a blow that should have broken me. What I had pieced together when the world around me was collapsing – it all burned. My hands burned. My hope burned. My belief that I could start over burned. I stood and watched the smoke rise into the gray sky, and inside me there was nothing. Only silence. Only emptiness.

I remembered how I started. How I took my child with me, changed diapers, fed him, and worked. How I bought a laser machine with the last money a friend had returned to me. How I got up at five in the morning and worked through the nights while everyone slept. I remembered how I made the first models, how clients came back, how I started breathing again. And now all of it lay in ashes. Black, cold, dead.

I looked at those ashes and felt no pain. Amazing. A year ago, I would have fallen to my knees, howled, smashed something, or run to a bottle. I would have gotten dead drunk to stop feeling that emptiness. I would have drowned myself in whiskey, like I used to. But I stood. I looked at the ashes and breathed. Something inside had changed. The pain was there, but it didn't consume me. It was somewhere nearby, like background noise, but I remained myself.

I remembered lying at the dacha, staring at the stairs and thinking: "If I fall – it'll all end." I remembered drinking through the nights while my child slept nearby. I remembered my wife looking at me with contempt, and I couldn't even meet her eyes. I remembered how worthless I was, a stinking alcoholic who couldn't even earn enough for diapers. And then I understood: I had already been through hell. I had already burned. And I had risen from that hell once. That meant I could do it again.

Then I lifted my head. Right above the charred roof, sunlight was breaking through. It was weak, gray, but it was there. And I felt invisible wings behind my back. Not real ones, of course – the kind that confidence gives. Freedom. I understood that I wasn't broken. I wasn't a victim. I had become a creator. Someone who has burned to the ground but risen from the ashes – he's not afraid of fire. He knows that ash isn't the end. It's soil for new growth. And every time I fell, I got up. Every time I lost everything, I started over. And now I knew: I wasn't alone. The Phoenix inside me – it had always been there. I had just forgotten about it. And now I remembered.

The Phoenix isn't just a beautiful metaphor. For me, it became reality. When I stopped being afraid of fire, stopped being afraid of losing, stopped being afraid of starting over – I became free. My "wings" are my hands, my head, my ability to make things. And they're always with me. You can't burn them. You can't take them away. They're the only thing that will stay with me until the end of my life. My hands, which created models for the president. My hands, which changed diapers and carried children. My hands, which didn't tremble even when I was drunk. They are my everything. And they're with me as long as I'm alive.

I stood on the ashes, looked at the sky, and breathed. And inside me there was no pain, no fear, no anger. There was certainty. I knew: I would build a new workshop. I would buy new machines. I would make new models. I would get my clients back. I would get back on my feet again. Because I'm not just a person who knows how to do something. I am the Phoenix. And I rise from the ashes every time I lose everything.

I remembered how my father taught me to hold a tool in my hands. How he said: "Hands won't betray you. Hands remember everything." And I held burnt plastic, scorched metal, fragments of what I had created. I held them, clenched them in my fists, and felt something new

boiling inside me. Not rage. Not resentment. Will. The very will I had lost somewhere among bottles and scandals. It had returned. As if it had been waiting for me to remember who I really am.

I remembered how, as a child, I was that boy who never let himself be bullied. That moment when I clenched my fist and punched my tormentor in the nose – and broke it. Then I understood: the last move was mine. And now, standing on the ashes, I felt that fist again. I felt again that the last move was mine. Not the fire's. Not fate's. Not circumstance's. Mine.

I stopped being a victim. I became a creator. And this moment – standing on the ashes and knowing that a new world would rise – this was the moment of my true freedom. I didn't know how long it would take before I got back on my feet. But I knew that I would get up again. Because I am the Phoenix. And I'm not afraid of fire. I am fire myself. It's inside me. It has always been inside me. I just needed to remember that.

When I looked around, I saw my children standing next to me. They were watching me. And there was no fear in their eyes. They saw that I wasn't broken. And that was the most important thing. Because when a father isn't broken, children aren't afraid. They have nothing to fear. They know: Dad will handle it. He always has. And he will handle it again. I smiled at them. I smiled, even though everything inside was burning. But I smiled. And they smiled back.

I didn't know what this new venture would be. But I knew that it was already growing inside me. Neural networks, 3D printing, helping others who had found themselves in my storm – this



wasn't just a "replacement" for the burned workshop. This was a new level. This wasn't a step back, but a step forward. I had stopped being the one who makes models. I had become the one who creates meaning. And if one of my businesses burned down, maybe fate was telling me: that's the past, look for something else, grow!

From that moment, my rebirth began. I didn't make plans, didn't write business ideas, didn't count money. I just walked, step by step. Day by day. I knew that I would put myself back together. And this time, I wouldn't put together the person others wanted to see. I would put together the person I was meant to be. Free. Strong. Alive. Real.

CHAPTER 8. "WHY YOU BECAME A DOORMAT. AND HOW TO STOP BEING ONE"

I can do a lot. I earn money, build a business, rebuild myself from the ashes. But in one thing I was blind – in relationships with women. Why did I, who can create a model for the president, who bought an apartment and cars, who carries everything on his shoulders – why did I become a servant in my own home?

The answer didn't come right away. It came from deep within, from childhood. I was raised like this: girls are future mothers, you have to give in to them, be their knight, their protector. My grandmother meant well. She didn't know she was raising not a man, but a doormat. She taught me to *earn* love.

And I earned it. Always. From childhood, I knew: love has to be deserved. You have to be good, convenient, reliable. You have to do everything to be valued. I carried the house, work, children, renovations, the mess no one cleaned up. I changed diapers while my wife slept. I washed dishes while she scrolled her phone. I did everything. And in return – coldness, reproaches, months without intimacy, insults in front of the kids.

The result: I was convenient. Convenient like an old couch. No one wanted me as a man. Because a convenient man doesn't excite. He inspires neither passion nor respect. He just exists. He works, pays, endures. You can wipe your feet on him.

And then I understood. I shouldn't have to earn love. Love isn't earned. It isn't deserved. It either is or it isn't. If feelings are mutual – they don't need proving, they attract on their own. A man who chases after a woman, puts her on a pedestal – loses himself. But a man who doesn't

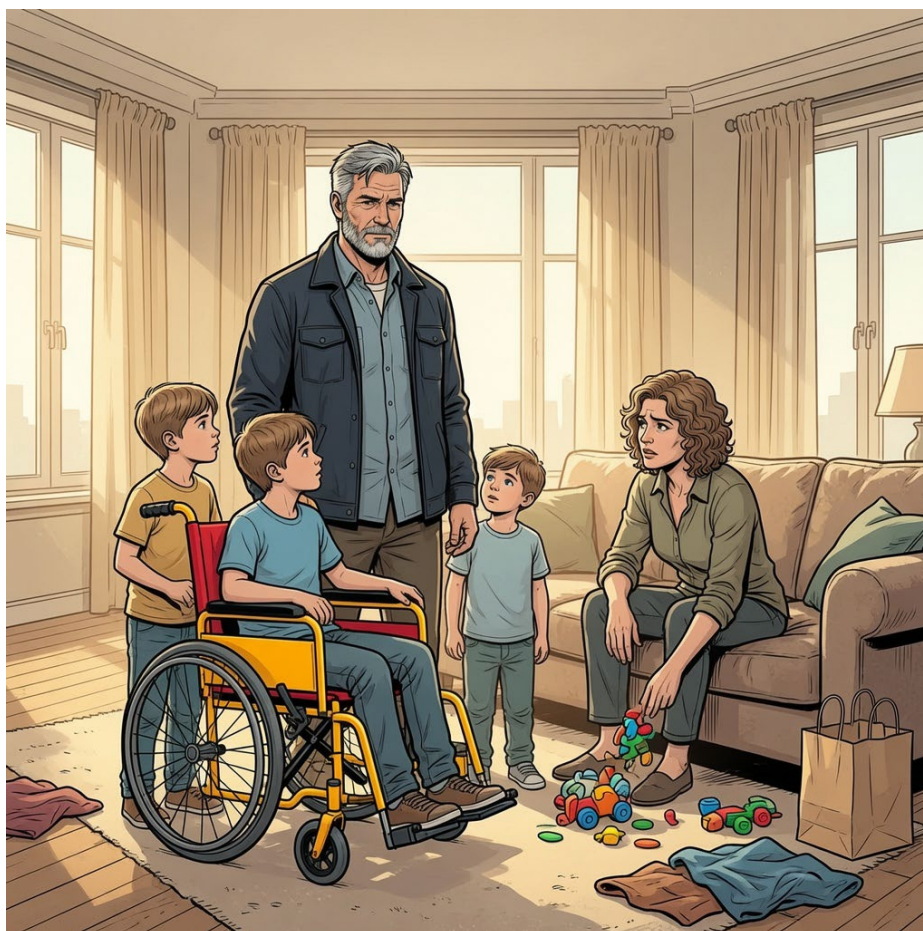
change his plans for her, who can put her in her place, who isn't afraid to be alone – women chase after *him* themselves. Women compete for such a man. Because he's worthy of the best. And the best woman herself wants to be with him.

Stop being convenient. Stop chasing. You can cook, wash, clean, earn, make plans all by yourself. Why do you need a parasite next to you who gives nothing? One who won't even have regular sex with you? You're not living your own life – you're serving hers, getting nothing in return.

But here's what's important. If a woman loved you and became a bitch under the pressure of your "nice guy" programming – don't rush to blame her. Start changing yourself. Grow up. Take back your rightful place as the head and master of the house. She will change too. I know this. That's exactly what happened with me.

Your internal reboot will show you who's next to you: a parasitic bitch you fed with your patience, or a person you yourself turned into that with your weakness. And then you'll see the truth. And you'll choose yourself. Not out of selfishness. Out of respect for who you've become.

I'm not saying all women are like that. I'm saying that I created this reality myself. With my softness, my fear, my habit of being good. And when I stopped being convenient – the world around me changed. Not right away. But it changed. Because a man who knows his worth doesn't seek approval – he doesn't demand it. He just lives his life, he isn't afraid to be alone. And those who want to be with him – stay. Those who don't – leave. And that's right.



It works the same way in business. Don't be convenient. Don't bow. Don't try to please at any cost. Because when you please – you lose yourself. And when you lose yourself – your value drops. Clients, partners, customers feel it. They feel that you're afraid to lose them. And then they start dictating terms, lowballing you, demanding more than you're willing to give. You become for them not a master, not an expert, but just an executor they can use.

And what happens when you just do your work? When you create value because you can't do otherwise? When you work on what your soul is drawn to, not on what they "order"? Then the world changes. You stop pleasing – and start attracting. Clients come to you on their own. They feel that you don't depend on their approval. And they respect you for it.

Don't try to be for everyone. Just be yourself. Create your own value. Believe me: for every product there will be a buyer, if that product is real. If it was made by your hands, your head, your soul. You won't be needed by everyone. But those who need you will stay with you for a long time. And that's worth much more than a crowd that uses you and leaves.

CHAPTER 9. A NEW LIFE



I stopped being convenient. Not to become "bad." But to become real.

The first thing I noticed – the world around me changed. Not right away. Not in one day. But gradually, as if someone had rearranged the scenery. My wife stopped yelling. She stopped reproaching me. She started looking at me differently. Not as a servant, but as a man. Not as someone who *has to*, but as someone who *chooses*. I'm not saying everything became perfect. We still have arguments. But now I don't swallow the resentment. I say what I think. And she listens. Sometimes she gets angry. But she no longer devalues me. Because she knows: I'm not someone you can step on. And this wasn't my "victory" over her. It was my victory over myself. I stopped waiting for her to change. I changed myself. And she adapted to the new reality. As if we were dancing – and I finally stopped backing away.

The second thing – I stopped being afraid of money. I used to think it slipped through my fingers, that I didn't deserve it, that it was "dirty." I was wrong. Money is energy. When I stopped fearing it, it stopped running away from me. I started counting. Planning. Saving. I bought new equipment. I made new models. I wrote this book. And I understood: money is not the goal. It's fuel for freedom. Not for buying things. For buying time. For having the right to say: "Today I work not because I have to, but because I want to." That's real freedom – not in the number of zeros in your account, but in the ability to choose.

The third thing – I stopped being afraid of being alone. I used to cling to relationships, to work, to habits, because I was afraid that without them I was nothing. Now I know: I exist even when no one is watching. I exist even when no one is applauding. I exist even when I'm alone. Loneliness stopped being frightening. It became a space where I can breathe. Where I can hear myself. Where I can piece myself back together. I understood that being alone isn't being forgotten. It's being yourself.

The fourth thing – I returned to my roots. To bronze. To what I started with. But I returned not as the same person who left. I returned with new skills. With 3D modeling. With experience in model-making, neural networks, and a new mindset. Everything I did from 2012 to 2025 – models, cities, railways, 3D printing – it wasn't wasted time. It was a new layer. I reimagined bronze through the lens of the digital world. I understood that old forms could be filled with new meaning. That you can create not just things, but meanings. And when I combined these two experiences – classical craftsmanship and modern technology – a powerful engine turned on inside me. It pushed me forward, gave me a second wind and a fresh perspective on what I can do and who I am.

My path was never straight. It was more like a spiral. I left to come back. I lost to find. I fell to learn how to get up. I burned to the ground to rise. And every time I thought everything was lost, I discovered that I had only lost what was holding me back. I lost chains. I lost fears. I lost false ideas about myself. And only I remained.

Recently I looked at myself in the mirror. And I asked myself one question: "Tell me, if they took everything away from you, what would be left?" Before, I would have answered: "Nothing." And that would have been an honest answer from someone who didn't know who he was. Today I have a different answer. Affirmative. Meaningful. Firm. "I would be left." The one who went through the storm. The one who saw the bottom. The one who didn't break. The one who knows he can start over at any moment, from any place, with empty hands, but with a full mind and a burning heart.

I don't know what will happen in a year. In five. In ten. I don't know if my wife will stay. I don't know if the business will grow. I don't know what storms the future will bring. But I know one thing: I'm no longer afraid of the unknown. Because inside me there is a core. The very one that wasn't there when I drank through the nights and stared at the staircase. That core I forged in the fire of my mistakes and tempered in my rebirth. I'm not perfect. I still make mistakes. I still doubt. Sometimes I get tired. Sometimes I'm afraid. But I no longer run. I stand.

A new man looked back at me from the mirror. That was my projection – or my truth. He was older than me. Calmer. He didn't seek approval. He wasn't afraid to be misunderstood. He



simply was. And I understood that I am him. I just didn't know it before. I searched for myself in other people's eyes, in money, in success, in alcohol. But I was here all along. Just locked in a cage I built myself. Now the cage is open. I've stepped out. And I'm not going back.

I am the Phoenix. I burned to the ground. I rose from the ashes. And now I know: I can go through anything. I already have.

Exercise for Chapter 9: "My Tomorrow"

Close your eyes and imagine: you've lost everything. All your money, all your relationships, all your status. What's left of you? Write it down. Then imagine: you're starting over from scratch, but with everything you've learned. What will you build? What's your first step? Not tomorrow. Today.

CHAPTER 10. CONCLUSION

I didn't write this book so you would feel sorry for me. I wrote it so you would know: there is a way out. It's not in a bottle. Not in money. Not in changing your wife. Not in a new job. It's in one decision – to take responsibility for your own life. To tell yourself: "From this day on, I am not a victim. I am a creator."

I don't promise it will be easy. I promise it will be honest. You will make mistakes. You will relapse. You will doubt yourself. But if you take one step today – tomorrow you'll take the second. The day after – the third. And in a year, you'll look back and won't recognize yourself.

I was where you are now. I know that storm. I know that emptiness. And I know that you can get out of it. Not because I'm stronger. But because I stopped waiting for someone to save me. And started saving myself.

I am grateful to my wife. Strange as it may sound. Through her behavior, her pressure, her reproaches, she helped me see where and what my mistakes were. She wasn't a villainess – she was a mirror in which I saw my own weakness. And when I changed, she didn't leave. She took her place. And I finally took mine. We both went through that storm. And we both came out of it different.

I am grateful to my disabled child. The very one who lay next to me while I drank through the nights. Who looked at me when I couldn't look at myself. He didn't let me jump into the abyss. He was my anchor when everything else was crumbling. Without me, he would have been lost. And without him, I would have been lost long ago. He kept me here, even when I didn't want to hold on myself.

Now it's your turn. Start with one step. Right now. Not tomorrow. Not on Monday. Now.

I believe in you. I was there – I know it's possible.

You are the Phoenix. And you've already begun to rise. You just haven't noticed yet.



EPILOGUE

Men, at the beginning of your relationships, you were gods to your young wives. You carried them in your arms, lit up the stars, promised them the world. But you never outgrew the role of the "good boy." You stayed convenient, obedient, afraid to say "no." And the girls grew into women who took control because you didn't take it. Then they stopped being your wives — they became your goddesses, and for some, your mothers. This is not their fault. This is the threshold you never crossed. But there is another way.

When a man chooses his path — a woman feels safe. She stops being a mother or a tyrant — and becomes your little girl. That is what a true marriage is. Not when you lead, and not when she leads. But when you lead — and she follows with trust and a smile.

I have walked this path. I was that "good boy" who endured, gave in, was afraid to offend. I wore the mask of a convenient husband until everything inside me burned away. I fell into my "gray storm" — loss of business, alcohol, emptiness. I lay at the bottom while the droppings of others' expectations rained down on me. And only when I stopped being convenient — did I begin to become real.

I do not offer you an easy path. I offer you a path where you stop being a victim and become the creator of your own life. Where you take control back from other people's voices and return it to yourself. Where you stop being a "good boy" and become the man a woman wants to follow.

If you take only one thing from this book, let it be this:

You are not a victim. You are the Phoenix.

You are not obligated to be who they made you to be. You have the right to choose yourself. And if you make that choice — your wife, your children, your world — everything will begin to change. Not because you become stronger. But because you become real.

You have already begun to rise. You are reading this book. You are searching for answers. This is the first step.

The road of detour leads to freedom. And freedom is when you choose your own life.



Alexander Katz

END OF THE BOOK.